



LEARNING

How to learn something hard

The methods that feel productive and the methods that work are mostly different methods.



DEFINITION

Desirable difficulty

A method that makes the session harder and the outcome better.

Slower today, still there in March. Most people abandon it in the first week.



Four moves that do the work

1 Retrieve before you review.

2 Space the sessions out.

3 Mix topics instead of blocking them.

4 Explain it to someone who will ask why.



Feels productive vs is productive

FEELS

highlighting,
rereading, watching a
walkthrough.

IS

blank page recall, old
problems with no
notes, teaching
it badly to a
patient friend.



What each move fixes

Retrieval	fixes forgetting
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Spacing	fixes decay
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Mixing	fixes knowing a method but not when to use it
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Explaining	fixes the gap you cannot see on your own
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Smooth is the warning sign

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If a session felt easy the whole way through, you rehearsed what you already knew. That is a review, and reviews do not add anything.



Pick one and run it for a month

Retrieval first if you only take one. It is the cheapest change and the one you will actually notice.

